Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "black = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Black is the colour of **darkness, night and coal**. Darkness limits information. You do not know what is behind the door or at the end of the road, and the imagination starts to work. That helps explain why black can relate to uncertainty as well as mystery.

From culture

In Europe black is linked with **mourning, celebration and authority**. A judge's gown, a dinner jacket, evening dresses, a funeral. At the same time it is the colour of fashion, photography and cultural projects. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

A black dress for a concert, a black coat from your grandmother, the first black T-shirt you bought yourself. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same black** and one feels support, the other weight.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "black" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does black connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Black has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

The Black Square

In **1915** Kazimir Malevich painted the picture Black Square, oil on canvas measuring 79.5 by 79.5 centimetres. He showed it at the 0.10 exhibition in Petrograd and, according to descriptions, had it hung in the so-called icon corner, that is, the place where icons used to hang in Orthodox homes.

Malevich said of his pictures that suprematism begins with them, and spoke of 1915 as the "zero point of painting". Four painted versions exist. Black here is neither sadness nor emptiness. It is **a decision to stop depicting and just be**.

A black car for everyone

The famous sentence "a customer can have a car painted any colour he wants so long as it is black" is attributed to Henry Ford and is said to date from 1909. According to an overview, though, the rule was introduced only in **1914**. From 1908 to 1913 the Model T was not offered in black at all, it came in grey, green, blue or red.

The reasons that repeat are low price, durability and fast drying. According to the same overview, though, there is no evidence that black dried faster than other dark paints. Black pigment was one of the cheapest. Black here did not become a fashion. It became **a practical decision**.

The blackest black

In July **2014** the company Surrey NanoSystems introduced the Vantablack coating. It consists of vertically growing carbon nanotubes and, according to the manufacturer, absorbs up to 99.965 percent of visible light. The name arose from the abbreviation VANTA (vertically aligned nanotube arrays) and the word black.

When the company granted the artist Anish Kapoor exclusive rights to artistic use, many other artists protested. Black became the subject of a dispute over **who may own a colour**. The later company Nanolab released its own nanotube-based black paint and eased the dispute.

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